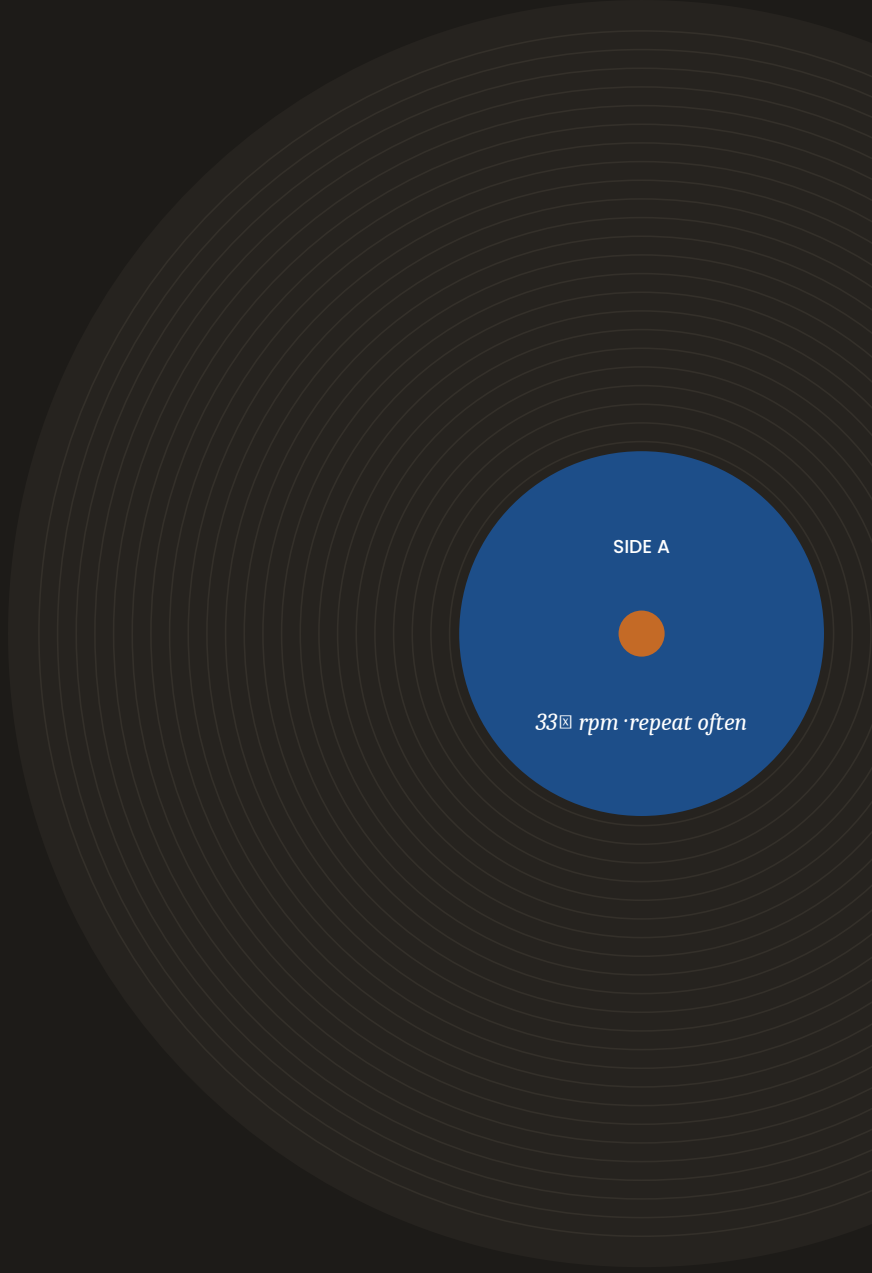


A FIELD GUIDE TO HEARING MORE

Ears Wide Open

How to listen to jazz — and keep getting better at it

Inspired by the listening lessons of Ted Gioia — How to Listen to Jazz & The Honest Broker

Prepared for Duncan Heidkamp · October 2026

BEFORE YOU PRESS PLAY

The premise

Jazz isn't a code you crack. It's a skill of attention — and attention can be trained.

Ted Gioia is a jazz pianist and historian who helped found Stanford's jazz studies program and wrote *The History of Jazz*, *The Jazz Standards*, and, in 2016, *How to Listen to Jazz*. Since 2021 he has written *The Honest Broker* on Substack. Across all of it runs one stubborn conviction: **careful listening can demystify almost everything that seems intimidating about jazz.** You don't need theory, a degree, or the right vocabulary. Gioia likes to point out that he learned the music at his local public library, checking out records and magazines — not in a smoky club.

This guide translates that idea into a practice. It paraphrases and organizes the listening principles Gioia teaches, then adds structure — exercises, a session routine, an eight-week plan, and a journal — so you improve the way you would at anything else: deliberately, a little at a time.

Five beliefs that run through Gioia's approach

1. **Listening beats jargon.** Critics often describe jazz in vague, impressionistic language. Gioia's alternative is concrete: here is what to listen for, here is a recording, now hear it yourself.
2. **Rhythm is the front door.** His book opens with rhythm and swing before anything else. If you can feel the pulse and hear how a band sits on it, the rest follows.
3. **Personality over notes.** What matters is not just which notes a player chooses but what they do to them — tone, attack, dynamics, timing. That is where a musician's identity lives.
4. **Structure frees you.** Jazz balances freedom and form. Once you can hear the form underneath, the improvising stops sounding random and starts sounding like storytelling.
5. **Stay open.** On *The Honest Broker* he urges readers to drop their preconceptions about genre and chronology, and to treat jazz as music for people who listen closely.

How to use this guide

Read one lesson, then do its exercise with headphones on before reading the next. Lessons 1–3 are skills; Lesson 4 is a map; Lesson 5 is about the present. The routine on page 8 and the plan on page 9 turn it all into a habit. Expect the real gains in weeks 3–5, when the same tracks start to sound completely different.

LESSON 1

Feel the swing

Gioia starts where the music starts: with rhythm. Swing is hard to define, but surprisingly easy to hear once you know what its absence sounds like.

Around the beat, not just on it

Great jazz rhythm isn't mechanical. Players lean slightly ahead of or behind the pulse, and the tension between the steady beat and where the notes actually land is a big part of what swing *is*. That's why Gioia argues a metronome can't capture it, and why drum machines rarely sound like a jazz drummer. Syncopation — accents that fall between or against the expected beats — gives the music its forward lean.

The engine room: bass and drums

In a swinging band, the bassist and drummer lock together. Listen for two things in particular: the **walking bass**, one note per beat, outlining the harmony; and the **ride cymbal**, the shimmering "ding, ding-a ding" pattern the drummer plays to carry the time. When those two agree, everyone else is free to float. Pairings worth studying: Walter Page and Jo Jones (Count Basie), Paul Chambers and Philly Joe Jones (Miles Davis's first great quintet), Jimmy Garrison and Elvin Jones (John Coltrane's quartet), and Ron Carter and Tony Williams (Miles's second great quintet).

Three tempos, three tests

- **The burn.** Very fast tempos show off virtuosity, but few bands can sustain them. Hear Charlie Parker's "Ko-Ko" and notice how the rhythm section holds it together.
- **The ballad.** Slow tempos tempt players to fill space with extra notes. The masters do less. Coleman Hawkins's "Body and Soul" (1939) is the classic study.
- **The medium groove.** Gioia treats a tempo a little faster than a resting heartbeat as the real proof of a band — nothing to hide behind. Try "Freddie Freeloader" on *Kind of Blue*.

TRY THIS

The "bad band" test (Gioia's own suggestion)

1. Find a video of a junior-high or high-school jazz band that hasn't learned to swing yet. Listen for two minutes. Notice how the rhythm feels stiff, rushed, or disconnected.
2. Immediately play the Count Basie Orchestra. The contrast is the lesson: you'll feel the swing as something physical, not a definition.

CUE UP Count Basie, "Jumpin' at the Woodside" (1938)

LESSON 2

Get inside the sound

The listener's job isn't only to follow the notes — it's to hear what the musician is doing to them.

Two saxophonists can play the identical melody and sound like different people. Gioia points listeners toward the qualities that make that true. These are the layers to train your ear on:

LAYER	WHAT TO LISTEN FOR	A CLEAR EXAMPLE
Tone	The fingerprint. Breathy or bright? Wide vibrato or none? Could you recognize this player from two notes?	Coleman Hawkins vs. Lester Young: big and robust vs. light and airy, on the same instrument
Dynamics	Loud and soft as storytelling. Does a phrase swell, whisper, explode?	Ben Webster's ballads: a growl, then a near-whisper
Articulation	How notes start and end: bends, smears, ghosted notes, a hard attack.	Louis Armstrong's opening cadenza on "West End Blues"
Phrasing	Where the player breathes, pauses, repeats an idea, answers themself.	Miles Davis on "So What": few notes, lots of space
Interplay	The conversation. Who is reacting to whom? Does the piano answer the horn?	Bill Evans Trio, *Sunday at the Village Vanguard* (1961)

Improvisation as storytelling

A good solo has shape: it states an idea, develops it, builds tension, and resolves. Try to hear a solo the way you'd hear someone telling a story at dinner. Where is the punchline? When does the player quote the melody, and when do they leave it behind? Sonny Rollins is a famous example of a player who develops a single motif for chorus after chorus — listen to "St. Thomas" on *Saxophone Colossus*.

TRY THIS

Sing along with Bird

1. Gioia's most audacious suggestion: put on Charlie Parker and try to sing (or hum) along with his lines. You will fail note-for-note. That's fine.
2. Repeat over several days. You'll start to feel the shape of bebop phrases in your body — where they accelerate, where they land — without knowing any theory.
3. Then try it with a slower soloist (Miles on *Kind of Blue*). Notice how much easier it is to follow, and how much the spaces matter.

CUE UP Charlie Parker, "Now's the Time" (1945) — a blues, so it also prepares you for Lesson 3

LESSON 3

Hear the architecture

Learn two shapes and you can follow most of the classic repertoire.

Shape 1 — The 12-bar blues

The foundation of a huge share of jazz. Twelve bars, three four-bar lines, built on three chords (I, IV, V). The first line states, the second answers, the third resolves. One trip through is one **chorus**.

Line 1 *Statement*	bar 1 **I**	bar 2 **IV**	bar 3 **I**	bar 4 **I**
Line 2 *Answer / variation*	bar 5 **IV**	bar 6 **IV**	bar 7 **I**	bar 8 **I**
Line 3 *Resolution*	bar 9 **V**	bar 10 **IV**	bar 11 **I**	bar 12 **V**

Shape 2 — The 32-bar song form (AABA)

The shape of most Broadway and Tin Pan Alley standards; Gioia walks through famous recordings eight bars at a time with this lettering. The **bridge** (B) is the contrasting section — listen for the moment the harmony seems to change the subject.

A 8 bars — the main tune	**A** 8 bars — tune again	**B** 8 bars — the bridge	**A** 8 bars — home

One chorus = 32 bars. Soloists improvise over this same shape, chorus after chorus.

The shape of a whole performance

Intro	Head	Solo 1	Solo 2	Solo 3	Fours	Head	Out

Melody stated → each player improvises over the form → drums trade short phrases → melody returns

TRY THIS

Count the choruses

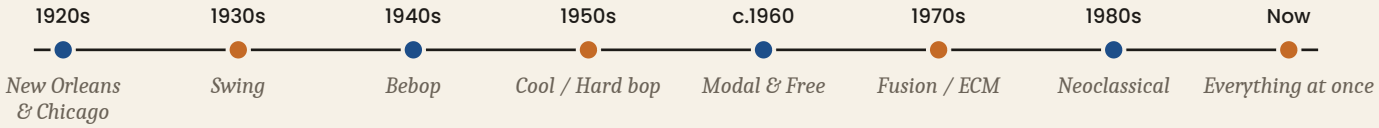
1. Play "Freddie Freeloader" (*Kind of Blue*). It's a 12-bar blues. Count bars on your fingers during the opening melody until you can feel where each chorus restarts.
2. Keep counting through the solos. Mark down how many choruses each soloist takes.
3. Switch to "So What" — an AABA tune where the bridge simply moves the whole band up a half step. Raise a hand every time the B section arrives.

CUE UP Miles Davis, *Kind of Blue* (1959), tracks 1 and 2

LESSON 4

Read the map

Gioia compares jazz to a buffet: many styles, each with its own flavor. You don't need to love all of them — you need to recognize them.



STYLE	WHAT DEFINES IT	ONE RECORDING TO START
New Orleans / Chicago (1920s)	Collective improvisation, the rise of the star soloist	Louis Armstrong & His Hot Five, "West End Blues" (1928)
Swing (1930s)	Big bands, dance rhythms, riffs passed between sections	Duke Ellington, "Ko-Ko" (1940); Count Basie, "One O'Clock Jump"
Bebop (1940s)	Small groups, fast tempos, complex harmony, music for listening	Charlie Parker, "Ko-Ko" (1945); Thelonious Monk, "Misterioso"
Cool & West Coast (late 1940s–50s)	Softer tones, arranged textures, restraint	Miles Davis, *Birth of the Cool*; Dave Brubeck, "Take Five"
Hard bop (1950s)	Bebop plus blues and gospel grit	Art Blakey & the Jazz Messengers, "Moanin'" (1958)
Modal & spiritual (c. 1959–65)	Few chords, long improvisations, searching moods	Miles Davis, *Kind of Blue*; John Coltrane, *A Love Supreme*
Free / avant-garde (1959 on)	Loosened or abandoned set chord changes and meter	Ornette Coleman, "Lonely Woman" (1959)
Fusion (late 1960s–70s)	Electric instruments, rock and funk grooves	Miles Davis, *In a Silent Way*; Weather Report, "Birdland"
ECM & global (1970s on)	Spacious, chamber-like, European and world influences	Keith Jarrett, *The Köln Concert*; Jan Garbarek
Neoclassical (1980s on)	Return to acoustic traditions and swing	Wynton Marsalis, *Black Codes (From the Underground)*
Today	Everything at once: hip-hop, electronics, global music, tradition	Kamasi Washington, *The Epic*; Makaya McCraven, *In These Times*

A tip for the map: after each new style, go back and play the one before it. Styles are easiest to hear by contrast — hard bop sounds earthier right after cool, and bebop sounds more radical right after swing.

LESSON 5

Listen forward

Two things that trip up new listeners: music that seems to have no rules, and the sense that jazz is a museum. Gioia pushes back on both.

Free jazz: feel it first

Avant-garde jazz often comes wrapped in heavy theory. Gioia's advice is to set the conceptual baggage down and respond emotionally first — in his words, "you can always come back and analyze it later." Practically, that means listening for texture, intensity, and how the players react to each other, instead of searching for a tune that isn't there.

- Start with something that still has a melody to hold onto: Ornette Coleman's "Lonely Woman".
- Notice the rhythm section: often still swinging hard even as the harmony floats free.
- Listen for call and response between instruments — it's a conversation without a script.

Jazz is a living music

The final chapter of *How to Listen to Jazz* turns to the present and ends with a list of 150 musicians in the early or middle stages of their careers worth following. The message: don't stop at the dead legends. A healthy listening life mixes the canon with musicians making records now, including the ways jazz is blending with hip-hop, electronic, classical, and global traditions.

Go hear it live

Gioia often recalls the electricity of his first jazz club, the feeling that anything might happen on the bandstand. A recording is a snapshot of one night; live jazz is the thing itself. Every skill in this guide works better in a room: watch the drummer cue the band, see a soloist signal the end of a chorus, notice who is listening to whom.

Share it

Reviewers of Gioia's book noted that one of its quiet lessons is that sharing jazz with others is the best way to deepen your own love of it. Make a five-track playlist each month for someone you know and explain, in one sentence per track, what to listen for. Teaching is the fastest way to find out what you actually hear.

TRY THIS

Old vs. new

1. Play John Coltrane's "Acknowledgement" from *A Love Supreme* (1964).
2. Follow it with a track from Kamasi Washington's *The Epic* (2015).
3. Write down two things that carried over, and two things that are clearly new.

THE PRACTICE

The five-pass listening session

One track, five times through, each time with a different job. Twenty-five minutes that will change how you hear everything else.

Set the room

On *The Honest Broker*, Gioia has championed Japan's jazz kissa — cafés built for focused record listening, where conversation stops and the music gets your full attention. Recreate that at home: phone in another room, good headphones or speakers, and one track or one full album rather than a shuffled playlist.

PASS	YOUR ONLY JOB	ASK YOURSELF
1 Whole	Just listen. No analysis.	What mood is this? Where did my attention go?
2 Drums	Follow the drummer the entire way.	Where's the ride cymbal? When do the accents push the soloist?
3 Bass	Follow only the bass.	Is it walking? Where does it land at the end of each chorus?
4 Soloist	Pick one soloist and stay with them.	Describe the tone in three words. What idea do they keep returning to?
5 Form	Count bars and choruses.	Blues or AABA? How many choruses per solo? Where are the fours?

After the five passes

1. Write three sentences in your journal (template on page 10): one about rhythm, one about a player's sound, one about how the piece is built.
2. Play the track once more, straight through. Notice how much more is happening than on pass 1.
3. Return to the same track a week later without notes. Retention is the skill.

> *"Deep before wide." Ten tracks you know inside out will teach you more than a hundred you've heard once. Re-listening isn't repetition — it's the actual training.*

THE PLAN

Eight weeks of listening

Three or four sessions a week, 25–45 minutes each. Each week adds one skill and keeps the earlier ones in play.

WEEK	FOCUS	CORE LISTENING	EXERCISE
1	Swing & pulse	Count Basie, "Jumpin' at the Woodside"; "Lester Leaps In"	Bad-band test. Tap along with the bass for whole tracks.
2	The rhythm section	"'Round Midnight" (Miles, 1956); "Footprints" (*Miles Smiles*)	Passes 2 & 3 only: drums, then bass. Compare the two drummers.
3	Tone & personality	Coleman Hawkins, "Body and Soul"; Lester Young with Basie	Three-word tone descriptions. Blindfold yourself: who's playing?
4	The blues form	"Freddie Freeloader"; Parker, "Now's the Time"; Monk, "Straight, No Chaser"	Count choruses. Sing along with Bird.
5	Song form (AABA)	"So What"; Art Blakey, "Moanin'"; Rollins, "Oleo"	Raise a hand at every bridge. Hum the melody under the solos.
6	Interplay	Bill Evans Trio, "Waltz for Debby" (Vanguard, 1961); Ahmad Jamal, "Poinciana"	Track who leads and who answers, bar by bar.
7	Breaking the rules	Ornette Coleman, "Lonely Woman"; Coltrane, *A Love Supreme*; Mingus, "Better Git It in Your Soul"	Feel first, analyze later. Write only adjectives.
8	Jazz now	Kamasi Washington, *The Epic*; Makaya McCraven, *In These Times*; Cécile McLorin Salvant	Old vs. new. Pick three living musicians to follow. Go hear a live set.

Album-length listening, alongside the plan

Once a week, play a whole record start to finish, no phone:

ALBUM	WHY IT'S HERE
Miles Davis, *Kind of Blue* (1959)	Clear forms, spacious solos: the ideal first textbook
Sonny Rollins, *Saxophone Colossus* (1956)	Thematic improvising and a great rhythm section
John Coltrane, *A Love Supreme* (1965)	A suite built to be heard as one arc
Bill Evans Trio, *Sunday at the Village Vanguard* (1961)	Three equal voices in conversation

Level check at week 8. Replay your week-1 tracks. If you can now name what the drummer is doing, describe the soloist's sound, and say where the form restarts, you've built the core skills. From here, follow your curiosity: pick a musician you loved and listen to everything they recorded in a five-year span.

YOUR NOTEBOOK

Listening journal

Copy this page or recreate it in a notebook. Writing forces you to hear specifically.

DATE / TRACK / ALBUM	
PLAYERS (WHO'S ON IT?)	
PASS 1: MOOD IN A FEW WORDS	
RHYTHM: WHAT THE BASS AND DRUMS ARE DOING	
SOUND: ONE SOLOIST'S TONE IN THREE WORDS	
FORM: BLUES, AABA, OTHER? CHORUSES PER SOLO?	
A MOMENT THAT SURPRISED ME (TIME STAMP)	
COMPARED WITH LAST TIME I HEARD IT	

Pocket glossary

Head — The composed melody, played at the start and end.

Changes — The chord progression the band improvises over.

Walking bass — A steady line, usually one note per beat, outlining the harmony.

Bridge — The contrasting B section of an AABA tune.

Syncopation — Accents placed off or against the expected beat.

Chorus — One full trip through the form (12 bars of blues, 32 of AABA).

Comping — Chords a pianist or guitarist plays behind a soloist.

Ride cymbal — The drummer's main timekeeping cymbal.

Trading fours — Soloists (often with the drummer) alternate four-bar phrases.

KEEP GOING

Go to the source

This guide is a study companion. The real teacher is Gioia himself — and the records.

How to Listen to Jazz (Basic Books, 2016)

The book this guide is built around. Chapters on rhythm, getting inside the music, structure, origins, styles, innovators, and jazz today, plus the list of 150 contemporary musicians. Start here.

The History of Jazz (Oxford, 3rd ed. 2021)

The full narrative. Read the chapter on any era right after you spend a week listening to it.

The Jazz Standards: A Guide to the Repertoire (2012)

Entry-by-entry essays on the tunes jazz musicians play, with recommended versions. Ideal for comparing many takes of one song.

The Honest Broker (honest-broker.com)

Gioia's Substack on music and culture. Search its archive for jazz pieces, album essays, and his recurring lists of recommended new music.

Habits that compound

- **Collect versions.** Pick a standard ("Body and Soul", "'Round Midnight") and hear five different recordings back to back.
- **Follow sidemen.** Check who's playing bass and drums on records you love, then follow them to other albums. It's the fastest way through the catalog.
- **Read liner notes and credits.** Recording dates and lineups turn a playlist into a story.
- **Go live once a month.** Sit close enough to watch the drummer.

About this guide. An independent study companion, not affiliated with Ted Gioia or his publishers. His ideas are paraphrased and organized here, with added exercises and recording suggestions; the single short quotation on page 7 is his. Song forms and recording details reflect standard jazz reference knowledge. For the full argument, and Gioia's voice, read the book.